



WHALE SWIM EXPEDITION

Tonga with Brooke Pyke: Swim with Humpback Whales

Eight days in Vava'u with award-winning underwater photographer Brooke Pyke. Across three 2027 departures, small groups of seven guests share five full private-boat days dedicated to responsible humpback whale swims, ocean confidence, image-making and the slow rhythm of island life.

DATES

Late Aug - Early Sep
2027

DURATION

8 Days / 7 Nights

LOCATION

Vava'u, Tonga

GROUP SIZE

7 guests

FROM

US\$5,300

HIGHLIGHTS

An intimate whale week shaped by ocean, culture and craft

01

5 Whale Swim Days

Five full days by private boat focus on humpback whale encounters when conditions, safety and whale behaviour allow.

02

Private Waterfront Base

Seven nights in private waterfront accommodation for a small group of just seven guests, close to the water and built around a calm expedition rhythm.

03

Brooke Pyke

In-water guidance, creative direction, ethical wildlife practice and image feedback from an award-winning underwater photographer.

04

Chef Prepared Meals

Daily meals by a professional chef, plus a traditional Tongan welcome feast to open the week with local warmth.

05

Blue Caves and Beaches

Between whale days, explore Vava'u's clear caves, remote beaches, coastlines and island viewpoints with local hosts.

06

Editing Masterclass

Brooke closes the week with a hands-on editing session, helping guests shape their images into a stronger story.

ABOUT THE EXPERIENCE

A rare window into the warm waters of Vava'u

Each year, humpback whales travel from Antarctica into Tonga's warmer waters. For a short seasonal window, careful, regulated swim encounters can become possible.

This journey is built around that possibility, not a promise. The group heads out each whale day with experienced local operators who read the animals, the weather and the water before any entry is made.

Brooke's role is to help you move with intention. She guides water confidence, light, framing, distance and patience, so the goal becomes more than getting close. It becomes understanding what is happening in front of you.

Beyond the whales, the week includes blue caves, remote beaches, island viewpoints, shared meals and the warmth of the Tongan community that makes Vava'u feel so different from a standard marine tour.



Every in-water moment is conditional. Weather, visibility, local rules, guide judgement and whale behaviour decide what is possible.

"The Airguides trip to Tonga to swim with humpback whales was the experience of a lifetime."

Mb Myers | Airguides Tonga guest



YOUR GUIDE

Brooke Pyke

Brooke is an award-winning Australian underwater photographer whose work is rooted in conservation, animal-first encounters and calm confidence in the water.

Entirely self-taught, Brooke has worked across the reefs of Western Australia, Indonesia, Tonga and the wider Pacific. Her images have earned international recognition and appeared in ocean publications including Oceanographic and EzDive.

On this expedition, she brings the field sense of a wildlife photographer and the patience of someone who understands that guests arrive with different levels of confidence. Her guidance is steady, practical and always shaped by respect for the animals.

"Photography and art have the power to ignite a passion for conservation in the next generation." – Brooke Pyke



WHY BOOK THIS EXPERIENCE?

More patience, more context and more care

A whale swim is not better because it is rushed or crowded. The best moments come when the group, the crew and the guide are patient enough to let the animals lead.

Private boat days give the experience room to adapt. If the ocean asks for waiting, you wait. If the whales are moving, the team makes measured decisions. If the right encounter does not present itself, the animal-first call is still the right call.

That is where Brooke changes the trip. She helps guests see beyond the obvious frame: behaviour, light, movement, emotion and the responsibility that comes with entering another animal's world.



DAY BY DAY

Your Vava'u whale swim itinerary

DAY		ARRIVAL
1	Welcome to Vava'u Arrive into Vava'u, transfer to your water-view accommodation, meet Brooke and the group, then open the week with a traditional Tongan welcome feast and Brooke's first whale behaviour masterclass.	
DAY		PREPARATION
2	Island Pace and Water Confidence Settle into mask, fins, breath and body position before the whale days begin. A local guide introduces beaches, lookouts and the cultural rhythm of the island.	
DAYS		WHALES
3-7	Private Boat Whale Swim Days Each day is dedicated to the water. The crew searches for spouts, fins and signs of calm whale behaviour. When an encounter is appropriate, Brooke helps with positioning, movement, light and respectful image-making. Lunches, reef stops, blue caves and remote beaches fill the spaces between whale opportunities.	
DAY		EDITING
8	Editing Masterclass and Farewell The boats stay at the dock while Brooke leads a hands-on editing session. Review the images you made, understand why certain frames work, then farewell the group with transfers arranged around onward travel.	



ON THE WATER

Five full days by private boat

The heart of the trip is time: five full days on the water with a private vessel and an experienced local whale operator.

Each day is shaped by conditions. The crew reads the surface, listens to local knowledge and watches the whales closely before deciding whether an in-water approach is appropriate.

Brooke stays close to the guest experience, helping with confidence, camera handling, composition and the quiet discipline needed for ethical wildlife photography.

5

full private-boat days focused on responsible whale swims

7

nights in private waterfront accommodation

1

underwater photography and whale behaviour masterclass

1

hands-on editing masterclass with Brooke

LIFE ON LAND

Waterfront accommodation, chef meals and island culture

The land component matters because the water can be intense. After each day at sea, guests return to a private waterfront base, shared dinners and the slower pace of Vava'u.

A professional chef prepares daily meals, while the welcome feast gives the group a first taste of Tongan hospitality. The itinerary also leaves space for blue caves, secluded beaches, lookouts, markets and quiet recovery between ocean days.

This is a small island community, not a resort bubble. The experience works because local operators, hosts and guides are central to the week.



Previous Tonga guests describe the whale encounters as mind blowing, but they remember the care of the team just as strongly.

Airguides Guest Feedback | Tonga

THE DETAILS

What's included

Included

- 7 nights private waterfront accommodation, twin-share basis unless confirmed otherwise
- Hotel and airport transfers in Vava'u
- Daily breakfast, lunch and dinner by a professional chef
- Traditional Tongan welcome feast
- Small group of 7 guests
- 5 full days of private boat time focused on responsible whale swims
- Underwater photography guidance with Brooke Pyke
- Humpback whale behaviour and ethical encounter guidance
- Hands-on editing masterclass with Brooke
- Private island touring, lookouts and local experiences
- Exploration of blue caves and secluded beaches when conditions allow
- Personal gallery of trip highlights captured by Brooke
- Airguides expedition leader and storyteller guide support

Wildlife encounters, boat routing, cave access and in-water time depend on weather, safety, local regulations and animal behaviour.

Not Included

- International and domestic flights
- Passport, visa or entry costs where applicable
- Travel insurance, medical costs and evacuation cover
- Personal snorkelling, freediving or camera equipment unless specified
- Alcoholic drinks
- Optional activities outside the confirmed itinerary
- Personal expenses, laundry and gratuities
- Single supplement or private room upgrades unless confirmed by Airguides

FAQ

What guests usually need to know

Can you guarantee whale swims?

No. Humpbacks are wild animals and every day is shaped by weather, visibility, sea state, local regulations and whale behaviour. The private boat structure and experienced local operators help create opportunities, but animal welfare and safety come first.

Is swimming with humpback whales ethical?

Tonga has regulated whale swim guidelines, and Airguides works with operators who prioritise the whales' comfort. Entries only happen when the crew judges the situation to be appropriate. If a whale is not receptive, the group does not force the encounter.

Do I need to be a diver?

No. This is a snorkelling experience. Humpbacks come to the surface to breathe, and the focus is calm surface interaction rather than scuba diving.

How confident in the water should I be?

You should be comfortable snorkelling in open water and able to manage several hours around boats, ladders, swell and changeable conditions. Brooke and the local crew support the group, but this is still an ocean expedition.

Do I need to be a photographer?

No. Brooke's guidance is valuable for camera users, but non-photographers still benefit from her wildlife knowledge, calm water coaching and conservation perspective.

What is Vava'u like?

Vava'u is a low-key island group in northern Tonga, with clear water, green hills, local restaurants, cafes, markets and a warm community feel. It is beautiful, remote and less polished than a resort destination.

What should I bring?

Bring your own mask, snorkel, freediving or snorkelling fins, wetsuit, reef-safe ocean layers, seasickness medication if needed and a reusable water bottle. Photographers should bring their camera, underwater housing, spare batteries, SD cards, lens cloths and a laptop with Lightroom Classic if they want to join the editing workflow.

PRICING & DATES

Tonga whale swim expedition: late August and early September 2027

TRIP PRICE

US\$5,300

Per person, based on the current public product page and pay-in-full price.

PAYMENT OPTIONS

US\$2,650

Deposit and final payment options should be confirmed directly with Airguides before booking.

3 departures

Late Aug - early Sep 2027

8 Days / 7 Nights

Vava'u, Tonga

7 guests

Availability, currency, payment schedule, room configuration and final inclusions should be confirmed with Airguides at the time of booking.

READY?

A rare Tonga whale week for travellers who want the ocean to mean more

Bookings are open for three small-group departures in late August and early September 2027. Get in touch to confirm availability and payment options.

Secure Your Place

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